



CHAUDHURI IS DISDAINFUL OF ANY EXCESS, WHETHER OF LANGUAGE, LIVING OR LOVING

EXCERPT

The notes of Bhimpalasi emerged from a corner of the room. Panditji was singing again, impatient, as if he were taking his mind off something else. But he grew quite immersed: the piece was exquisite and difficult. He'd composed it himself seven years ago.

From not far away came the sound of traffic; the roundabout, bewildering in its congestion. Bullocks and cars ground around it. The bulls looked mired in their element; the buses and dusty long-distance taxis were waiting to move. The car horns created an anxious music, discordant but not indifferent.

The Panditji wasn't there: he'd died two years ago, after his third cardiac seizure. They had rushed him to Jaslok Hospital; on the way, in the car, he'd had his second heart attack. He had died in Jaslok, to the utter disbelief of his relatives: they hadn't thought that he'd been admitted to a hospital to die. Now, his presence, or his absence, persisted in the small seven-hundred-square-foot house. The singing had come from the tape recorder, from the tape the grandson had played accidentally, thinking it was a cassette of film songs.

'Yeh to dadaji ke gaane hai,' remarked the boy, recognizing his grandfather's singing; was he surprised or disappointed? Next to him hung a portrait of his *dadaji*, enlarged from a photograph taken when he was fifty-seven. The face was an austere one, bespectacled, the oiled hair combed back. It was the face of—by common consensus in the family—a great man. The large forehead had been smeared with a tilak, as if someone had confused the portrait with a real person.

rising to a crescendo of unbearable beauty, nor crashing and jangling and tearing at your innards and your emotions as music (or literature) is sometimes wont to do. For Chaudhuri's strength, sometimes, is also his peculiar limitation, if you are looking for a novel that twists your guts with joy or pain.

If you are looking, however, for a prose that smoothly travels down your gullet like a fine malt on a wet winter evening, for a plot that turns on nothing more dramatic than the slow and meticulous honing of melodious voices in a stately waltz of upper crust Bengaliana in Bombay as a

boy grows from childhood through adolescence into nascent adulthood, and for characters disarmingly mundane and almost familial as they glide from day to humdrum day in lives as intricate and yet as insignificant as each of ours ultimately is—then *The Immortals* is certainly the novel for you to sink into, like a tired body on to a lush sofa, anticipating a long mellow lyrical journey through a story told with full-throated ease. *The Immortals* sings of seasons unripe and fruitful, of ambitions frustrated and fulfilled, of poetic, poignant words set to magical, mystical tunes filling up days and nights of musical longing in Bombay—as a boy metamorphoses into a man and learns the lessons of life through his lessons in music.

Chaudhuri principally traces three lives through three singular, colliding and yet coalescing musical sensibilities in this novel which is as much about music as it is about the three who live and practise and pursue it: Shyam Lal, the son of "heavenly" singer Ram Lal who is beleaguered for being far less talented than his father and remains constantly embarrassed under the weight of unreasonable expectations of his musical ability, and his two students, the mother-son duo of Mallika and Nirmalya Sengupta. Mallika is gifted with a voice that is so lovely that it can potentially melt the stoniest soul, but neglects her music for the doubtful pleasures of directing her household of plenty, as the wife of a successful businessman. The young Nirmalya is a precociously thoughtful, moody, sometimes-unpredictable single child who rather self-consciously courts the status of a mini-rebel in an affluent home, airing his disapproval of his parents' social whirl with his scraggy appearance and studiously cavalier behaviour. Not surprisingly, perhaps, Nirmalya is a flaming, if brusque, flag-bearer of art for art's sake, and passionately believes that a perfunctory pursuit of artistic excellence—when one is blessed with talent—is sacrilegious.

And here lies the charming, olde-worlde essence of *The Immortals*, in the rescue of a sublime classical music from a big bad Bombay of crass commerce and shallow societal gigs, in the redemptive power of high art married to an almost arcane passion for its many-splendoured promise. Music nestles at the heart of the city of Bombay despite its fame as a financial hotspot, and Chaudhuri retrieves it with a quiet but assured faith. There can be little doubt that he considers it adequate recompense for the horror and hustle of modern life. And he can, with his lilting, liquid flow of words, even make you believe it. ■